The `:file` option takes an absolute file-system path. Of course, you need to have rights to the view that you're using to render the content.
By default, the file is rendered using the current layout.

If you're running Rails on Microsoft Windows, you should use the `:file` option to render a file, because Windows filenames do not have the same format as Unix filenames.

2.2.5 Wrapping it up

The above three ways of rendering (rendering another template within the controller, rendering a template within another controller and rendering an arbitrary file on the file system) are actually variants of the same action.

In fact, in the BooksController class, inside of the update action where we want to render the edit template if the book does not update successfully, all of the following render calls would all render the`edit.html.erb` template in the `views/books` directory:

```
render :edit
render action: :edit
render "edit"
render "edit.html.erb"
render action: "edit"
render action: "edit.html.erb"
render "books/edit"
render "books/edit.html.erb"
render template: "books/edit"
render template: "books/edit.html.erb"
render "/path/to/rails/app/views/books/edit"
render "/path/to/rails/app/views/books/edit.html.erb"
render file: "/path/to/rails/app/views/books/edit"
render file: "/path/to/rails/app/views/books/edit.html.erb"
```

Which one you use is really a matter of style and convention, but the rule of thumb is to use the simplest one that makes sense for the code you are writing.

2.2.6 Using `render` with `:inline`

The `render` method can do without a view completely, if you're willing to use the `:inline` option to supply ERB as part of the method call. This is perfectly valid:

```
render inline: "<% products.each do |p| %><p><%= p.name %></p><% end
%>"
```

There is seldom any good reason to use this option. Mixing ERB into your controllers defeats the MVC orientation of Rails and will make it harder for other developers to follow the logic of your project. Use a separate erb view instead.

By default, inline rendering uses ERB. You can force it to use Builder instead with the `:type` option:

```
render inline: "xml.p {'Horrid coding practice!'}", type: :builder
```

2.2.7 Rendering Text

You can send plain text - with no markup at all - back to the browser by using the `:plain` option to `render`:

```
render plain: "OK"
```

Rendering pure text is most useful when you're responding to Ajax or web service requests that are expecting something other than proper HTML.

By default, if you use the `:plain` option, the text is rendered without using the current layout. If you want Rails to put the text into the current layout, you need to add the `layout: true` option and use the `.txt.erb` extension for the layout file.